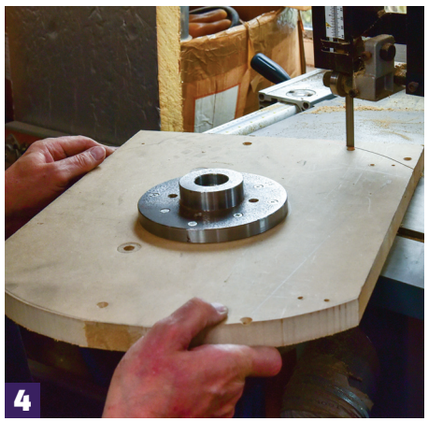

3 Having made sure the wood fits on the MDF board, mark the centre and planned extremities on your piece of crotch wood

4 If the rectangular MDF looks a bit scary, round off the corners to make it safer. Keep clear of the spinning edges nonetheless

5 Secure a cork pad in the centre of the MDF faceplate using double-sided tape. This helps protect the bark while centering the blank. Unfinished cork tiles are a great non-marking, slightly compliant material for use in jigs. Press the blank against the cork pad with a revolving centre to adjust the height of the wings for the finished piece

6 Secure your wood to the faceplate and ensure you are happy with its safety. My initial plan was to mount the blank to the MDF with screws using a scrap block for support. Unfortunately one of the 125mm screws jammed in the green wood, then snapped when getting it out, so I realised this wasn't going to work. If you are in any doubt about the safety of an awkward shaped piece, stop and re-think, then make sure it is safe

7 A more secure method of fixing is to square off the ends of the piece and use scrap blocks to attach the crotch to your faceplate. As a belt and braces measure, use screws and glue. Ensure you only screw into areas that will be cut away later

8 If your piece is out of balance, which it almost certainly will be with a crotch, add a counterweight to enable you to turn safely at a realistic speed. I used a 12mm bolt and penny washers. This will enable you to accurately balance even the most unusually shaped blanks, and you can easily adjust it as you turn the wood away

9 Start the lathe slowly and increase speed as far as possible without undue vibration. With something like this all you will see is a blur, so it's important to know where the wood is. Position the rest to 'protect' yourself from touching extremities that are difficult to see. Start hollowing using a medium bowl gouge. Initially it is fairly easy as the tool is mostly in contact with the wood. Stop the lathe frequently to see progress from an aesthetic and safety perspective. Make sure you can quickly and easily get to your stop button, particularly when you are turning more challenging pieces

10 Take notice of all your senses when turning, look, listen and feel what is going on, you will often get an early warning of something about to go awry. Having heard some slightly different sounds, I stopped the lathe to find a large void which was soft and could be marked with my thumbnail. Luckily it wasn't that big so could be turned away

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